together.

“What is it?” Léa asked, slipping down from the bunk bed and joining Rose at the window.

“There are people outside. I think something’s happened.”

“Let’s get dressed,” Léa said.

Rose strapped Katya to her chest in the sling, then put on her coat and boots. Halfway down the stairs, they met the night guard, an anxious look on his face.

“Fräulein Cotillard, there are injured people on the street—” his voice trembled “—they’ve walked all night.”

“From where?” Léa asked.

“Dresden,” his eyes went wide. “What they’ve said . . .”

Rose felt a chill along her spine. “Did something happen in Dresden?”

“Come quickly. I’ve given them water.”

They followed him outside. The air was bitterly cold; frost covered the ground. As Rose approached the gate, she could see a man hunched over two women sitting on the ground. The sharp smell of ash and smoke hung on their clothing. The man had a stiff blanket wrapped around his shoulders as if he’d dunked it in water, then draped it over himself and it froze in that position. He turned to Léa, streaks of blood on his face and shards of glass on his skin, his eyes bloodshot and swollen.

“What’s happened?” Léa asked.

“They bombed Dresden,” he said, coughing.

The younger of the two women whimpered, holding up her arm; the skin on her hand was bloodied and black. “Flames everywhere, the sky on fire,” she said, breathless. “A wind carried the flames like waves devouring all . . .”

The third woman looked up. She had cuts all over her face, and a black eye with a bruise that swelled down to her cheek. “Windows blown out, glass hit us from all directions.”

“We tried to seek shelter in the train station, but it was a ball of fire, completely destroyed.”

Léa glanced at Rose, who wanted to tell her not to worry, Reinhardt had a plan. She squeezed her sister’s hand instead.

“We need to get them to the sick bay,” Léa said. “Josef will clean their eyes with drops, then tend to the cuts on their faces and hands.”